

Cessationism

prc-cessationism

Spiritual Gifts · Sign Gifts · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

score 0.762
confidence medium

Statement under examination

The miraculous sign gifts (apostleship, prophecy, tongues, miraculous healings) ceased with the apostolic age and the closing of the canon.

In plain language

The proposition says the miraculous sign gifts ended with the apostolic age and the closing of the canon. The key passage is 1 Corinthians 13:8-10. There prophecy and knowledge are said to be abolished using the verb *katargeo* in the future passive, while tongues will cease using a different verb, *pauo*, in the future middle. The trigger for the abolishing is the coming of *to teleion*, the complete or perfect thing. The single Greek word *teleios* does not by itself say what the complete thing is. Across the New Testament it can mean mature persons, or morally complete states, or a finished or whole thing. The text gives a time clause, whenever it comes, but does not name a date. So the words allow a reading where the complete thing is the finished body of revelation, and they also allow a reading where it is the final state described in the very next verse as seeing face to face, knowing fully as one is fully known. That next verse, with now versus then and face to face vocabulary, is the strongest single reason readers diverge. Ephesians 2:20 places apostles and prophets in a foundation image with Christ as cornerstone, which fits an argument that the foundation is laid once and not repeated. Hebrews 1:1-2 contrasts God speaking long ago in the prophets with speaking in the Son in these last days, and Hebrews 2:3-4 describes signs and wonders as past confirmation of the message that was heard from the Lord. Second Corinthians 12:12 calls the cluster of signs, wonders, and powers the signs of the apostle. These verses lean toward a confirming and foundational function, but none states an end date for the gifts in plain words. Working in the other direction, 1 Corinthians 12:7-11 lists prophecy, tongues, and miracles as Spirit-given operations distributed as he wills, and chapters 14 and 1 Thessalonians 5 give standing rules for using and testing these gifts with no expiry clause attached. Acts 2:17 reads Peter as quoting Joel of the last days, naming the whole church age as the period of Spirit-given prophesying. Because the central word leaves its referent open and the surrounding texts pull in more than one direction, the lexical data sustains competing readings and does not settle the timing. The honest lexical verdict is therefore disputed rather than a clear yes or no.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	79
G0737	ἄρτι	arti	now	37
G1100	γλῶσσα	glossa	tongue	50
G1108	γνῶσις	gnosis	knowledge	29
G1411	δύναμις	dynamis	power	120
G2310	θεμέλιος	themelios	foundation	16
G2673	καταργέω	katargeo	to abate	27

G2980	λαλέω	laleō	to speak	
G3313	μέρος	meros	part	42
G3973	παύω	pauo	to cease	15
G4383	πρόσωπον	prosopon	face	77
G4394	προφητεία	propheteia	prophecy	19
G4396	προφήτης	prophetes	prophet	149
G4592	σημεῖον	semeion	sign	77
G5046	τέλειος	teleios	perfect	19
G5059	τέρας	teras	wonders	16
G5119	τότε	tote	then	162

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The lexical pattern at 1 Cor 13:8-10 is materially contested. Prophecy and knowledge take the future passive of katargeo (G2673, will be rendered inoperative), tongues take the future middle of pauo (G3973, will cease), and the trigger for the abolishing verbs is the arrival of to teleion (G5046, the complete or perfect, neuter singular). The Greek does not lexically fix what to teleion refers to. The temporal clause hotan elthe leaves the date open, and the immediate context (v.12) glosses the contrast with arti (G0737, now) seeing di esoptrou en ainigmati (through a mirror in a riddle) versus tote (G5119, then) prosopon pros prosopon (G4383, face to face), which lexically tilts the referent toward eschatological seeing rather than canon completion. On the other hand, Eph 2:20 places apostles and prophets in the themelios (G2310, foundation) of the household with Christ as akrogoniaios (cornerstone), and Heb 1:1-2 and 2:3-4 cast the prophetic and sign-and-wonder vocabulary in the past-confirming frame (ebebaiotē, synepimartyroutos). 2 Cor 12:12 ties ta semeia tou apostolou (G4592 + G0652) specifically to apostolic identity. These three vectors lexically support a foundational reading. Neither vector dates the gifts in plain words, and the present-tense gift catalog of 1 Cor 12:7-11 plus the standing regulatory imperatives of 1 Cor 14 and 1 Thess 5:19-21 carry no expiry clause. The lexical store sustains both readings without adjudicating between them, which is the textual reason this verdict lands at disputed.

Scripture

1Cor.13.8 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2673 καταργέω, G3973 παύω, G4394 προφητεία, G1100 γλώσσα, G1108 γνώσις

Force. Three distinct cessation verbs are deployed in one verse. Prophecies and knowledge are governed by the future passive of katargeo (G2673, katargethesontai, will be rendered inoperative or abolished); tongues take the future middle pausontai (G3973, will cease). The voice contrast between the passive of katargeo and the middle of pauo is a real lexical datum, pressed by some as evidence that tongues cease of their own accord prior to the other two gifts, and by others as semantic parallelism for the transience of present partial gifts under love. The verbs alone do not date the cessation; that is set by the dependent temporal clause introduced in v.10.

1Cor.13.9 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3313 μέρος, G4394 προφητεία, G1108 γνώσις

Force. Present knowing and prophesying are qualified as ek merous (G3313, in part, partial). The partiality is set in explicit contrast to to teleion in the next verse, framing the present gifts as provisional. The lexeme meros marks incompleteness but does not by itself date the terminus.

1Cor.13.10 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5046 τέλειος, G3313 μέρος, G2673 καταργέω

Force. When to teleion (G5046, the complete or perfect, neuter singular substantive) comes, to ek merous will be abolished (katargethesetai). The referent of the neuter substantive to teleion is the lexical crux. Across 19 NT occurrences teleios ranges over mature persons (1 Cor 14:20, Eph 4:13, Heb 5:14), morally or relationally complete states (Jas 1:4, 1:25), and finished or whole things (Heb 9:11). The temporal clause hotan elthe (whenever it comes) does not specify whether the coming is the completion of revelation, corporate maturity, or the eschatological face-to-face of v.12. The lemma alone does not fix the date, which is why the cessation timing is contested.

1Cor.13.12 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0737 ἄρτι, G5119 τότε, G4383 πρόσωπον, G1108 γνώσις

Force. The immediate gloss on to teleion. arti (G0737, now) we see di esoptrou en ainigmati, but tote (G5119, then) prosopon pros prosopon (G4383, face to face); arti I know ek merous, tote I will know fully even as I have been fully known. The arti and tote pair the present partiality of v.9 with a future state characterized by direct, unmediated sight and exhaustive mutual knowledge. The phrase prosopon pros prosopon is OT idiom for direct divine encounter, and the perfect passive epegnosthen (I have been fully known) describes an exhaustive knowing that is most naturally read as eschatological rather than canon-bound. This verse is the strongest lexical reason the cessation timing is disputed rather than settled in favor of an apostolic-age terminus.

Eph.2.20 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος, G4396 προφήτης

Force. The household of God is built (epoikodomethentes, aorist passive participle, having been built upon) upon the foundation (themelios, G2310) of the apostles and prophets, with Christ as akrogoniaios (cornerstone). The foundation metaphor lexically situates apostles and prophets at the structurally non-repeating base of the building, which supports an inference that the foundation-laying office is laid once and not relaid. The aorist participle marks a completed founding event. The metaphor speaks to office function and contains no explicit verb of cessation for charismata generally; it bears on the apostolate and the foundational prophetic role, not on tongues or healings as such.

Heb.1.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2980 λαλέω, G4396 προφήτης

Force. God spoke palai (of old) in the prophets polymeros kai polytropos (in many parts and many ways), then ep eschatou ton hemeron (in these last days) in a Son. The temporal adverbs contrast a prior prophetic mode of speech with a definitive Son-mediated speech, which supports a redemptive-historical reading that the prophetic mode reached its terminus in the Son. The verse lexically concerns the mode of divine revelation in the prophetic office, not the cessation of congregational charismata as such, and ep eschatou ton hemeron names the present church age as the last days rather than a closed past.

Heb.2.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4592 σημεῖον, G5059 τέρας, G1411 δύναμις

Force. God co-witnessed (synepimartyrountos, present participle of joint-attestation) the proclaimed salvation by semeiois (signs), terasin (wonders), and poikilais dynamesin (various miracles). The participle is governed by the aorist ebebaiotē (v.3, the salvation having been confirmed) describing a past confirming act by those who heard the Lord. The grammar casts the sign cluster in a confirmatory function attached to the original proclamation, which supports a confirmatory reading. The verse states no explicit terminus or perpetuity for the signs themselves; the temporal force comes from ebebaiotē pairing the signs with the once-confirmed message.

2Cor.12.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4592 σημεῖον, G0652 ἀπόστολος, G5059 τέρας, G1411 δύναμις

Force. Ta men semeia tou apostolou kateirgasthe en hymin: the signs of the apostle were worked out among you in all endurance, in signs and wonders and powers (semeiois te kai terasin kai dynamesin). The genitive tou apostolou (G0652) is most naturally read as defining or appositional, attaching the same sign cluster (semeia, terata, dynameis) to the marker of apostolic identity. The grammar gives a category label, the signs of the apostle, that lexically ties the cluster to apostolic office. It does not by itself say the signs cannot appear elsewhere, but it does anchor the cluster to a defining function of apostleship.

1Cor.12.7 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1411 δύναμις, G4394 προφητεία, G1100 γλώσσα

Force. The manifestation (phanerosis) of the Spirit is given to each one (hekasto) for the common good, and the catalog in vv.8-11 lists miracles (energēmata dynameon), prophecy, kinds of tongues, and interpretation as present operations apportioned by the one Spirit kathos bouletai (as he wills). The present-tense distribution language describes the gifts as operative in the Corinthian congregation without any temporal limiting clause. The catalog lexically complicates a hard cessation-at-canon reading because it embeds no expiry.

1Cor.14.31 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4396 προφήτης, G4394 προφητεία

Force. Dynasthe gar pantes propheteuein: you can all prophesy, one by one, so that all may learn and all be exhorted. The regulatory instructions across 14:26-33 treat prophecy, tongues, and interpretation as ongoing congregational practices to be ordered, not phased out, and contain no clause assigning them an expiry. The present-tense imperatives lexically complicate a reading that the gifts are intrinsically apostolic-only.

1Thess.5.20 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4394 προφητεία

Force. Propheteias me exoutheneite, alla panta dokimazete. Do not despise prophecies, but test all things and hold the good. The negative imperative both legitimizes prophecy as ongoing and subordinates it to evaluation, presenting prophecy as a fallible-yet-valued congregational function. The lexical force neither perpetuates nor terminates the gift on a fixed date.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.13.10	1Cor.13.12	tsk	1
1Cor.13.9	1Cor.13.12	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	Eph.4.11	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	Isa.28.16	tsk	1
1Cor.14.32	1Cor.14.29	tsk	1
1Cor.14.31	1Cor.14.3	tsk	1
Heb.2.3	Heb.5.9	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.13.12 · addressed

Treated as a primary scripture entry rather than only a cross-reference because it lexically glosses to teleion. The arti versus tote pair, the prosopon pros prosopon idiom for direct divine encounter, and the perfect passive epegnosthen for exhaustive knowing read most naturally as eschatological immediacy, which weighs against a canon-completion referent for to teleion and is the strongest single lexical reason the cessation timing is disputed rather than settled. Recorded as a genuine countervailing datum without forcing it to resolve in either direction.

1Cor.12.7 · addressed

The present-tense apportionment of miracles, prophecy, and tongues kathos bouletai is addressed as a lexical complication. The catalog shows the gifts operative in the congregation without an embedded expiry clause, so any cessation terminus must be argued from to teleion at 13:10 or from the foundation metaphor at Eph 2:20 or from the apostolic-sign appositional at 2 Cor 12:12, not from the gift list itself.

1Cor.14.31 · addressed

The regulatory imperatives for ongoing prophecy and tongues are addressed by noting that they govern present practice and assign no terminus; they neither establish perpetuity nor preclude a later cessation, so they are recorded as complicating but not decisive against a foundational reading.

1Thess.5.20 · addressed

Me exoutheneite plus panta dokimazete is addressed as presenting prophecy as a valued-but-testable ongoing function; the imperative carries no temporal limit, so it complicates a hard cessation reading without refuting a foundational one.

Acts.2.17 · addressed

Peter's Pentecost citation of Joel runs en tais eschatais hemerais, in the last days, naming the church age as the last days during which God pours out his Spirit so that sons and daughters prophesy. The lexical force of the genitive hemeron eschaton is to extend the prophetic outpouring across the whole period inaugurated at Pentecost. This complicates a strict apostolic-age terminus but does not by itself date the cessation of any particular gift; it is addressed by recording it as a real countervailing time-marker.

Concordance traversed

G2673, G3973, G5046, G3313, G4394, G4396, G1100, G1108, G2310, G4592, G5059, G1411, G0652, G0737, G5119, G4383

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

1Cor.13.8/pesei-piptei-katargethesetai at 1Cor.13.8: impact none. Some witnesses read ekpiptei or piptei (falls) for the ouedepote clause governing he agape, and for the knowledge clause some apparatuses mark a fall verb alongside katargethesetai. Apparatus marks piptei in the bundle. The substitution swaps one fall or abolish verb for another and does not change the disputed status of the cessation timing or the to teleion referent.

1Cor.13.10/to-tote at 1Cor.13.10: impact none. Minor article and word-order marks at to ek merous do not alter the lexical crux, which is the unspecified referent of to teleion, so the verdict is robust across the cited readings.

Pauline corpus is outside the published ECM scope for v1; treated as ecm-shadow. The cited variant units do not bear on the disputed verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. cessationism, continuationism, open-but-cautious

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

cessationism: affirms · Reads to teleion (G5046) at 1 Cor 13:10 as the completion of the deposit of revelation; reads the foundation metaphor of Eph 2:20 (themelios, akrogoniaios, the aorist epoikodomethentes) as a non-repeating foundational office held by the apostles and the foundational prophets; reads Heb 1:1-2 as a redemptive-historical transition from prophetic to Son-mediated speech; reads Heb 2:3-4 as casting sign and wonder vocabulary in the past-confirming participial frame (synepimartyroutos under ebebaiothe); and reads 2 Cor 12:12 ta semeia tou apostolou as appositionally tying the sign cluster to apostolic identity. The cumulative inference is that the attesting and foundational gifts lapsed once the message was confirmed and the apostolic office passed.

continuationism: denies · Reads to teleion as the eschatological state, anchored by 1 Cor 13:12 (arti vs tote, prosopon pros prosopon, perfect passive epegnosthen) where the contrast is now-partial seeing versus then-direct exhaustive knowing. Presses the present-tense gift apportionment of 1 Cor 12:7-11 (kathos bouletai) and the ongoing regulatory imperatives of 1 Cor 14:26-33 and 1 Thess 5:19-21, none of which embed an expiry. Reads Acts 2:17 en tais eschatais hemerai as naming the entire church age as the period of Spirit-given prophesying, so the gifts persist until the parousia. Notes that no NT text gives an explicit date or verb of cessation for the sign gifts.

open-but-cautious: disputed · Holds that the lexical store underdetermines the referent of to teleion at 1 Cor 13:10 and the force of the voice contrast between pausontai (middle) and katargethesontai (passive), so neither a hard cessation tied to the apostolic age nor an unqualified continuation can be established from the words alone. Notes that the foundational and confirmatory vocabulary lexically anchors a structural argument while the present-tense catalog and regulatory imperatives lexically anchor an experiential argument, and the canon supplies both patterns without ranking them.

The verdict turns substantially on the unspecified referent of to teleion at 1 Cor 13:10 and on whether the foundation, confirmation, and apostolic-sign language entails a terminus for the gifts. Progressive-revelation framing (Heb 1:1-2) bears on the cessation argument, hence analogia_scripturae and progressive_revelation are marked true, but the primary method remains grammatico-historical because the crux is lexical-grammatical (the open referent of one neuter substantive and the absence of an explicit cessation date).

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Whether the miraculous sign gifts (apostleship, prophecy, tongues, miraculous healings) continued beyond the apostolic age, or instead ceased with the apostolic age and the closing of the canon.

The stem asserts the cessation outcome and pairs it with a specific terminus (apostolic age and canon closing), which preloads the disputed referent of to teleion and a framework conclusion. The neutralized form poses continuation versus cessation as an open question on equal lexical footing. The verdict is still derived on the original stem and returned as disputed because the lexical data sustains more than one defensible reading.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.13.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.13.10
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.13.12
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.20
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.2.4
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.12.12
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5046
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2673
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3973

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0652
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4383
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.13.10
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.13.12
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.13.10
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.2.20
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	1Cor.13.8

License audit

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Reason. Citations include MACULA-Greek (CC-BY-NC-4.0, non-commercial, redistribute false) for the syntactic anchoring of to teleion at 1 Cor 13:10 and the arti/tote/prosopon construction at 1 Cor 13:12, and SBLGNT-text (SBLGNT-EULA, redistribute false) for the base Greek text. Either source alone makes the bundle non-redistributable for bulk publication.

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TSK	public_domain	yes
SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow